

Melchor's Notes on Nyxeram

For centuries, the Mantle of Nyxlanyss has been passed down through the royal family. The monarch who wears the Mantle is given the authority to rule as well as defenses against magic and Dark miasma. Although it has historical significance, the Mantle is more than it appears at first glance. The Mantle's true form is Nyxeram, the Nightmare of the Depths.

Nyxeram is a being believed to be as old as the caverns of Lorosfyr itself, though none know their true origin. Their name means "nightmare;" "Nyx" comes from the primordial goddess of the night, and "eram" reversed finishes the title. They most commonly take the form of a tattered mantle with a crooked face and two barbed horns. They can take many forms, although unlike most shapeshifters, they do not have a true form to revert to (as discovered when Joanna the Wise cast moonbeam during her battle with Nyxeram over 300 years ago). They have taken advantage of their form as the Mantle of Nyxlanyss to guide the monarchs of the city to perpetuate the city's cycle of torment and misery.

Due to their nightmarish nature, it has been found that they have the inherent ability to read the thoughts and emotions of those around themselves. A mind blank spell has been found to successfully thwart this ability (as discovered by Nemea the Mad, the court wizard 120 years ago). Queen Dahlia has discovered another method for shielding her mind which shall not be written here; this allows her to choose which thoughts and emotions Nyxeram hears. Those who cannot protect their minds and hearts are left vulnerable to Nyxeram's manipulations; they seem to enjoy bringing others to their own ruin, driving people down paths that lead to self-destruction.

A better known example of this manipulation comes from the story of Harkon the Betrayer which occurred a mere 80 years ago. Harkon resented being passed over for the position of First Warden. Nyxeram whispered promises of vengeance into his mind, driving him to more and more acts of unnecessary brutality. Eventually, Harkon found the Talisman of Ultimate Evil and used it to slay the new First Warden. For his crime, Harkon was sentenced to death, although he hid the Talisman before he could be caught. To this day, the location of the Talisman is still unknown.

Nyxeram has been known to attempt to turn back travellers from descending past the city. They warn of the dangers ahead and are willing to give said travellers what they desire in exchange for abandoning their journey. One such example was that of Omen Vortex, the prior mayor of the

Blackmount Citadel. He and his companion, Lord Asheblade, sought to raise an empire and slay their foes, and so they descended into Lorosfyr. In return for turning back from their journey, Nyxeram gave Omen riches and magic, and Lord Asheblade received a twisted sword which drained life from its victims. Although it seemed like they got what they wanted for free, Nyxeram's bargains always result in suffering. Both men were ultimately defeated and left worse off than when they started. Lord Asheblade was reduced to a mere wraith cursed to wander the caverns below the citadel while Omen was sealed away in the citadel's catacombs to rot until freed once more.

Although Nyxeram has led many down paths of destruction, they do not rely on falsehoods in doing so. They may withhold information or say true things that result in misunderstanding, but they do not directly lie. This may seem strange at first, but upon further consideration, the true reason becomes clear. If they lie and a person falls to ruin because of it, they can easily fault Nyxeram for their downfall. However, if Nyxeram does not deceive them, then the ruined person can only blame themselves for their own folly.

Nyxeram's combat capabilities are nothing to be trifled with. They can act with impressive strength and agility, causing serious harm to their foes. They also have considerable defenses; due to their shadow nature, the effectiveness of nearly all forms of damage is reduced considerably; they are resistant to magical effects and can even avoid harm altogether (as seen when Nyxeram was left unharmed by a cone of cold during their battle with Perry the Frostmancer 280 years ago). More concerningly, when close to death, they can sacrifice their offensive capabilities to become nearly impervious to all forms of harm until they recover.

Although they may seem invulnerable, it is believed that the Tear of First Light, a powerful artifact of light, may be the only thing capable of truly destroying them. The artifact has been lost for some time, likely as a result of interference by Nyxeram, and as such, its true properties are unknown. However, the powerful light within, antithetical to darkness, should be enough to bypass Nyxeram's defenses and ultimately destroy them. If the Tear of First Light is not enough, then nothing else will be.

Overpowering Nyxeram exists as an alternative to destruction. Efforts have been made to control Dark Miasma, somewhat successfully. If our Queen can gain the power to command it in full, then she will have the power to do as she wills without interference from Nyxeram. In so doing, she will bring the city of Nyxlanyss to a new age, one that does not need the Nightmare of the Depths at its head in order to persist.